

# COMS30026 Design Verification

# **Verification Hierarchy**

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(Acknowledgement: Avi Ziv from the IBM Research Labs in Haifa has kindly permitted the re-use of some of his slides.)



# Outline

- Observability and Controllability
  - Black box, white box and grey box testing
- Verification hierarchy
  - Levels at which to perform verification



# Observability and Controllability



# Observability and Controllability



- **Observability:** Indicates the ease at which the verification engineer can identify when the design acts appropriately versus when it demonstrates incorrect behavior.

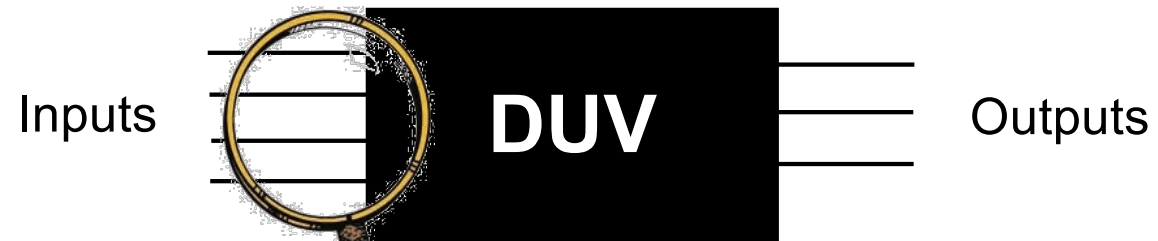


- **Controllability:** Indicates the ease at which the verification engineer creates the specific scenarios that are of interest.

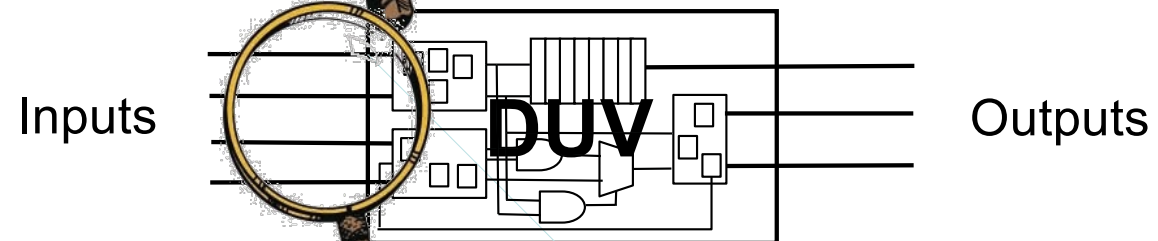


# Levels of Observability

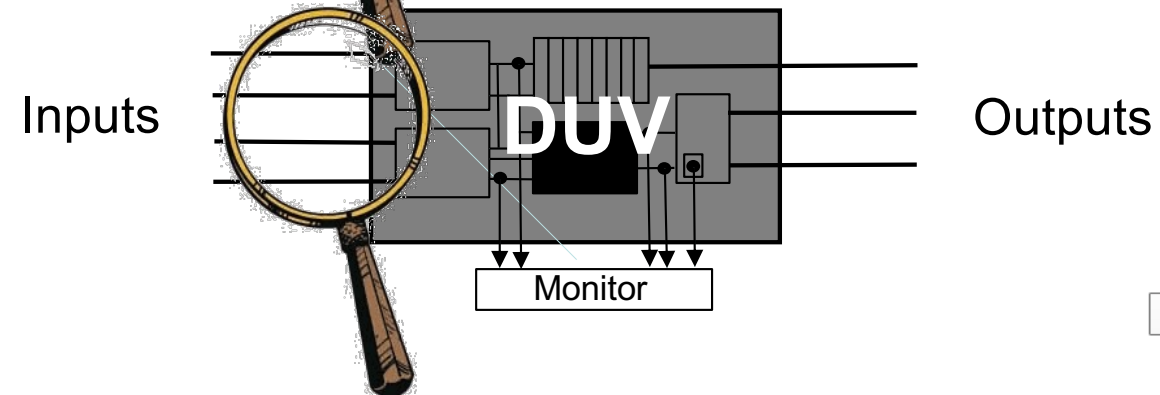
- Black Box



- White Box



- Grey Box



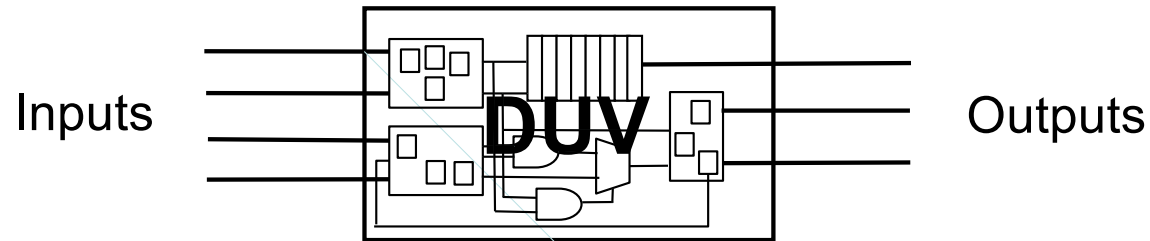
# Black Box Verification



- The black box has **inputs, outputs, and performs some (well documented) function.**
- To verify a black box, you need to **understand the function.**
- The verification code utilizes only the external interfaces.
- The internal signals and state remain in the dark.
- **Pros:**
  - No knowledge of the actual implementation is required.
  - Ability to predict functional results based on inputs alone ensures that the reference model remains independent from the DUV implementation.
  - Verification code is less sensitive to changes inside the DUV.
- **Cons:**
  - Difficult to locate source of problem, only exposes effects. (If at all! Remember, not all bugs propagate to the outputs.)
  - **Lacks controllability and observability.**



# White Box Verification

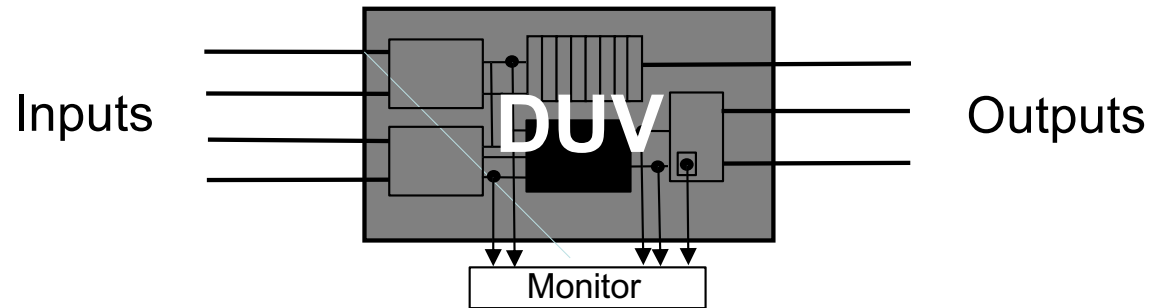


(Opposite of black-box approach.)

- For white box verification the internal facilities of the DUV are known, visible and utilised for verification.
- **Pros:**
  - **Full visibility and controllability of internal signals.**
    - **Can identify and cover corner cases.**
    - **Can detect bugs as soon as they occur.**
  - Quickly possible to set up interesting conditions, e.g. counter roll-over.
- **Cons:**
  - Danger to follow the implementation/design instead of the specification.
  - Sensitive to changes in the DUV (implementation).
  - Too many details make it hard to create and maintain.



# Grey Box Verification



- For grey box verification a limited number of DUV facilities are utilised in a mostly black-box environment.
  - Access important and stable features, the rest is kept in the dark.
- Combines the pros (if done the right way) or the cons (if done the wrong way) of black and white box.
  - Progression from black box to grey box should be carefully planned and started only when the **DUV is sufficiently stable**.
- In practice: **Most verification environments are grey box.**
  - May need to start with black box with planned evolution into grey box.
  - Note: Prediction of correct results on an interface is occasionally impossible without viewing an internal signal.



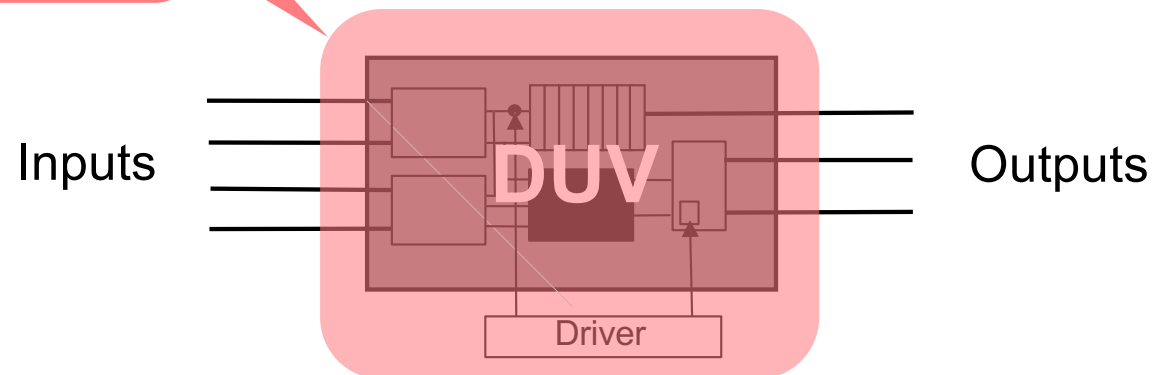


# Levels for Controllability

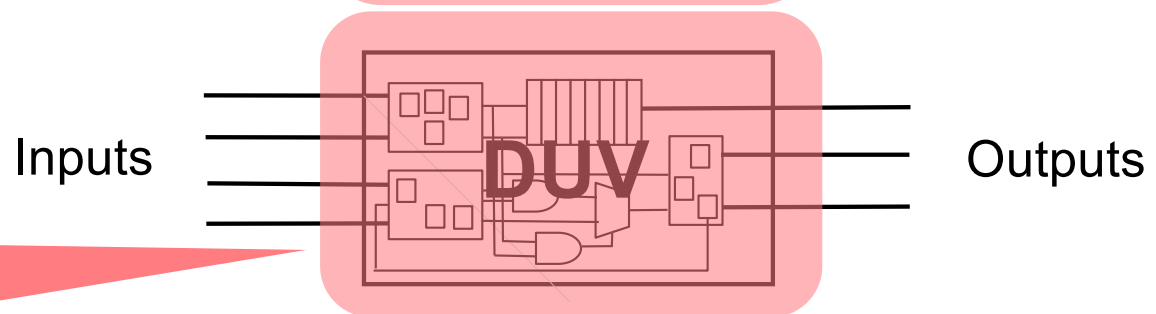
- Black Box



- Grey Box



Watch out for unreachable states!



# Be careful with White Box Controllability

- In theory, the same levels as for observability also exist for controllability:
  - black, grey and white box
- In practice:
  - **We seldom control the internals of the DUV.**
  - This may drive the design into a state that is **not reachable *under normal circumstances***.
  - It may thus lead to an inconsistent DUV state.
- The main exception: **Warm Loading**
  - Brings the DUV to a predefined interesting state.
    - E.g. cache initialization, almost full buffer
  - Reduces the time needed for reaching this state.



# Verification Hierarchy



# Verification Hierarchy

- Today's complex chips and systems are divided into logical units
  - Usually determined during specification / high-level design
  - Usually follow the architecture of the system
  - This practice is called **hierarchical design**
- Hierarchical design allows a designer to subdivide a complex problem into more manageable blocks
  - The design team combines these blocks to form bigger units, and continues to merge/integrate these blocks until the chip or system is complete



# Pros and Cons of Hierarchical Design

## ■ Pros

- Breaks the design into manageable pieces
- Allow designers to focus on single function / aspect of the design

## ■ Cons

- More interfaces to specify / design / verify
- Integration issues



# Levels of Verification

- Verification usually adapts to and takes advantage of the hierarchical *design* stages and boundaries
- Common levels of verification
  - Designer level (block level)
  - Unit level
  - (Core level)
  - Chip level
  - System level
  - Hardware / software co-verification



# Designer (Block) Level Verification

- Used for verification of single blocks and macros
- Usually, done by the designer him/herself
- Main goal – Sanity checking and certification for a given block
- Ranges from a simple test of basic functionality to complete verification environments
- The common level for formal verification



# Unit Level Verification

- A set of blocks that are designed to handle a specific function or aspect of the system
  - E.g., memory controller, floating-point unit
- Usually there is a formalized spec
  - More stable interface and function
- The target of first serious verification effort





# Core Level Verification

- A core is a unit or set of units designed to be used across many designs
  - Well defined function
  - Standardized interfaces
- Verification needs to be thorough and complete
  - Address all possible uses of the core
- The verification team can use “Verification IP” for the standardized interfaces



# Chip Level Verification

- Verification of a set of units that are *packaged* together in a physical entity
- Main goals of verification
  - Connection and integration of the various units
  - Verify functions that could not be verified at lower levels
- Need verification closure to avoid problems at tape-out



# System Level Verification

- The purpose of this level of verification is to confirm
  - Interconnection
  - Integration
  - System design
- Verification focuses on the interactions between the components of the system rather than the functionality of each individual component

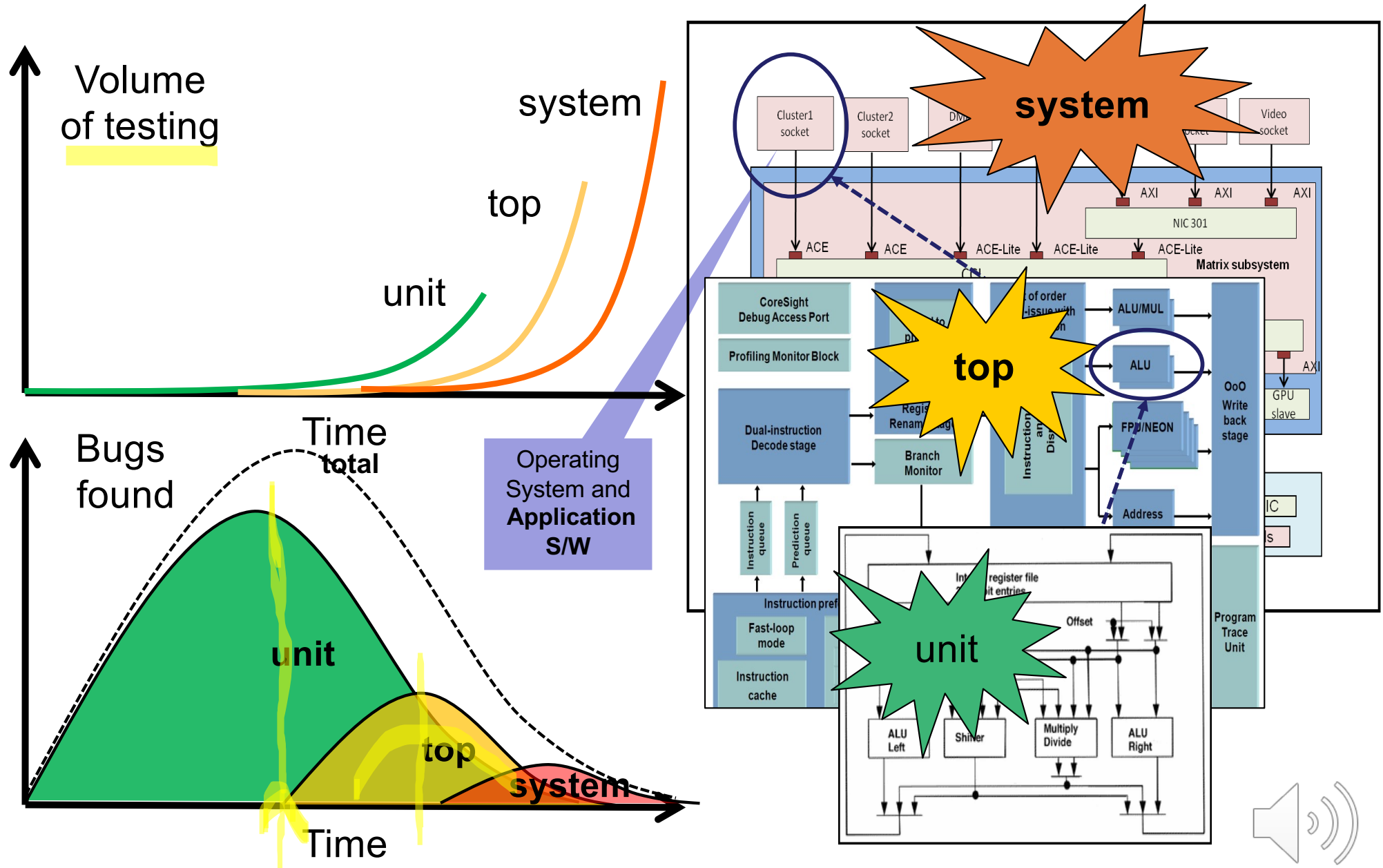


# HW / SW Co-Verification

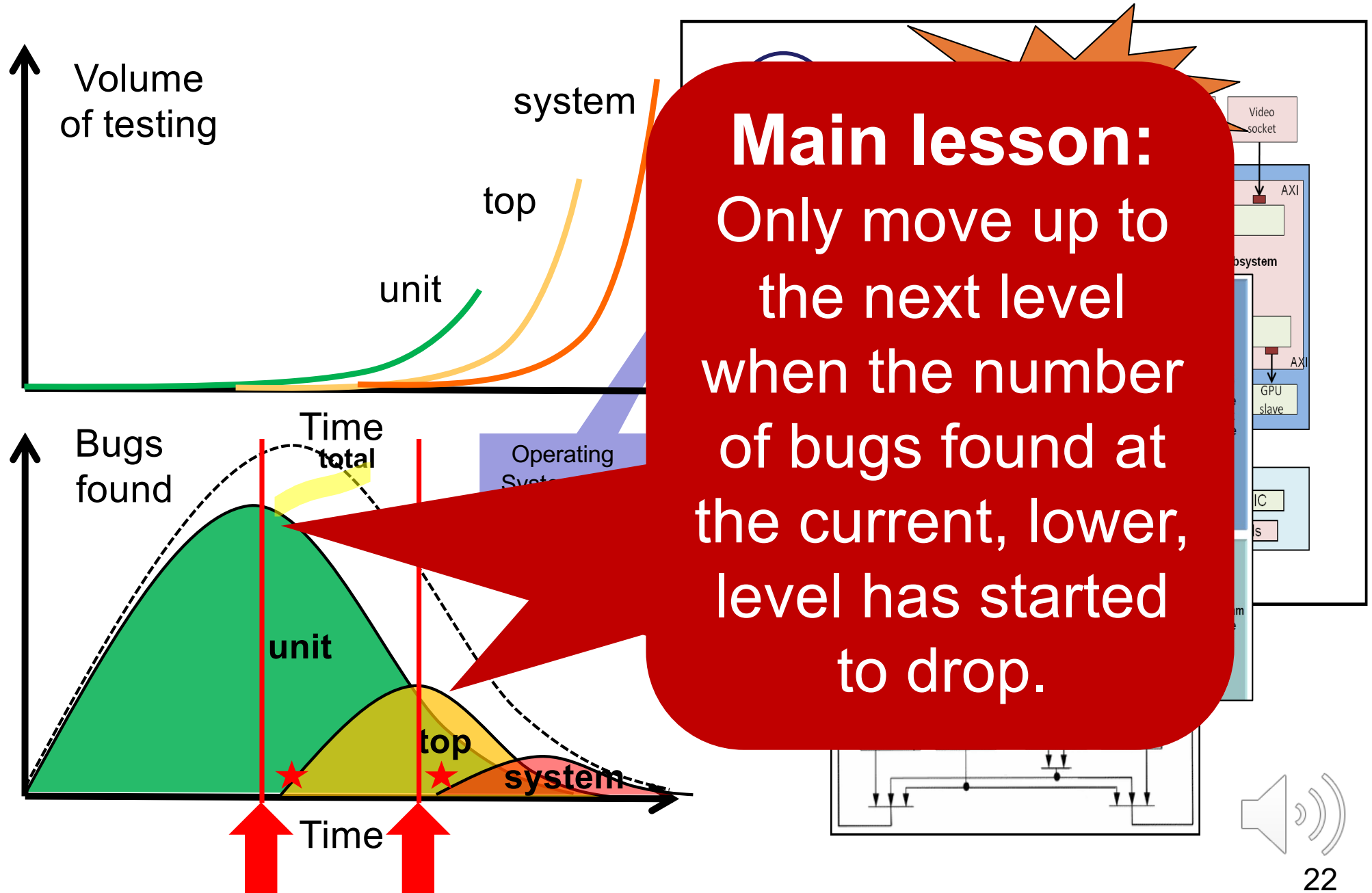
- Marries the system-level hardware with the code that runs on it
- Combines techniques from the hardware verification and software testing domains
- This combination creates many issues
  - Different verification / testing techniques
  - Different modes of operation
  - Different speed
- Beyond the scope of this course



# Verification at different Design Levels



# Verification at different Design Levels



# Which Level To Choose?

- **Always choose the lowest level that completely contains the target function under verification**
- Each verifiable piece should have its own specification
- Function to be verified may dictate the appropriate level for verification
- The selected level must provide suitable controllability and observability to perform verification



# Which Levels to Verify?

- In general, each level that is exposed to the “outside world” is mandatory
  - For example, chip level, system level
- The rest depends on many factors
  - Complexity
  - Risk
  - Schedule
  - Resources





# Summary

We have investigated

- Observability and Controllability
  - Black box, white box and grey box testing
- Verification hierarchy
  - Levels of verification
  - Importance of selecting the appropriate level for verification

Always choose the lowest level that completely contains the target function under verification.



# Next

- Recordings of lectures (about 2h - 3h per week)

## Week 1:

- ✓ Introduction to Design Verification
- ✓ Verification Hierarchy
- ✓ Driving & Checking

- [uobdv.github.io/Design-Verification/](https://uobdv.github.io/Design-Verification/)  
shows a **weekly schedule of topics** to watch  
BEFORE the next session, ideally
- Recordings are available from Blackboard unit page

- Tasks for you this week:
  - **Attend the lab session** on Thursday to set up access to the EDA tools
  - **Paper review “*The limits of correctness*”**

# Paper review

*Brian Cantwell Smith. 1985. The limits of correctness.  
SIGCAS Comput. Soc. 14,15, 1,2,3,4 (Jan 1 1985), 18–26.  
DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1145/379486.379512>*

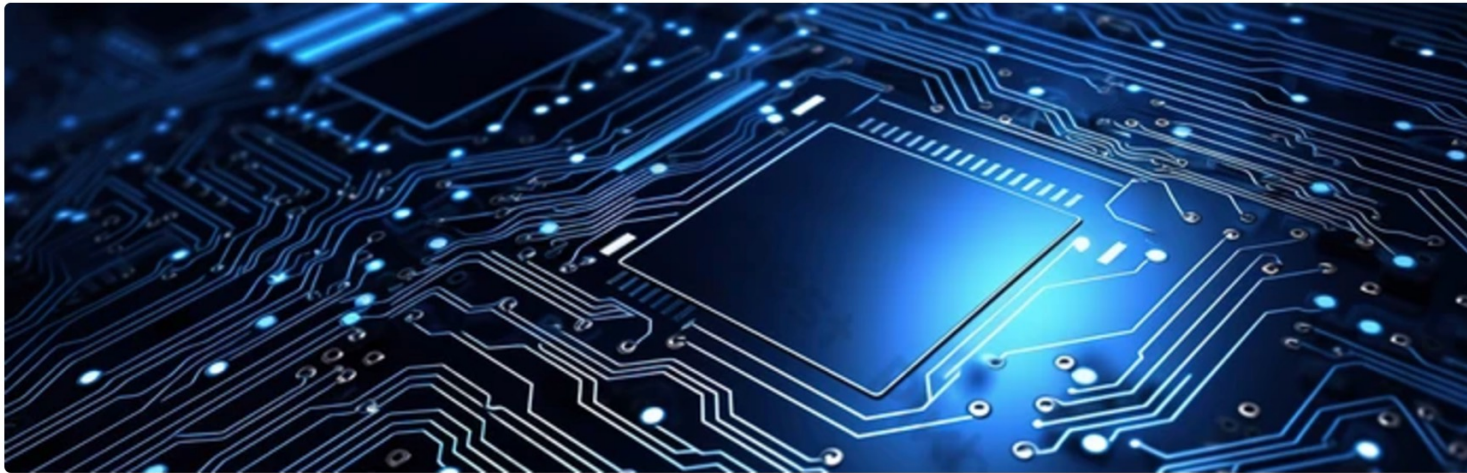
THE LIMITS OF CORRECTNESS<sup>†</sup>

Brian Cantwell Smith\*

- *Identify the main lines of argument*
- *Why does the author question the notion of “correctness”?*
- *What are the two or three key take-away messages for you?*

Over the last ten years, the Defense Department has spent many millions of dollars on a new computer technology called "program verification" - a branch of computer science whose business, in its own terms, is to "prove programs correct". Pro-

And my answer, to give away the punch-line, is no. For fundamental reasons - reasons that anyone can understand - there are inherent limitations to what can be proven about computers and computer programs. Although program verification is an important new technology, useful, like so many



## WEBINAR: Verification Productivity Trends

Select tickets

Fri 24 Oct 2025 12:00 PM - 1:00 PM CDT

📍 Online

### Verification Productivity Trends

Verification teams are constantly pressured to deliver faster, with fewer bugs, and on increasingly complex designs. This webinar will explore how “shifting left” is transforming verification practices, making them more productive, predictable, and scalable.

We'll discuss the latest productivity trends in verification, and hear perspectives from leading companies on how methodologies, tools, and best practices are evolving.

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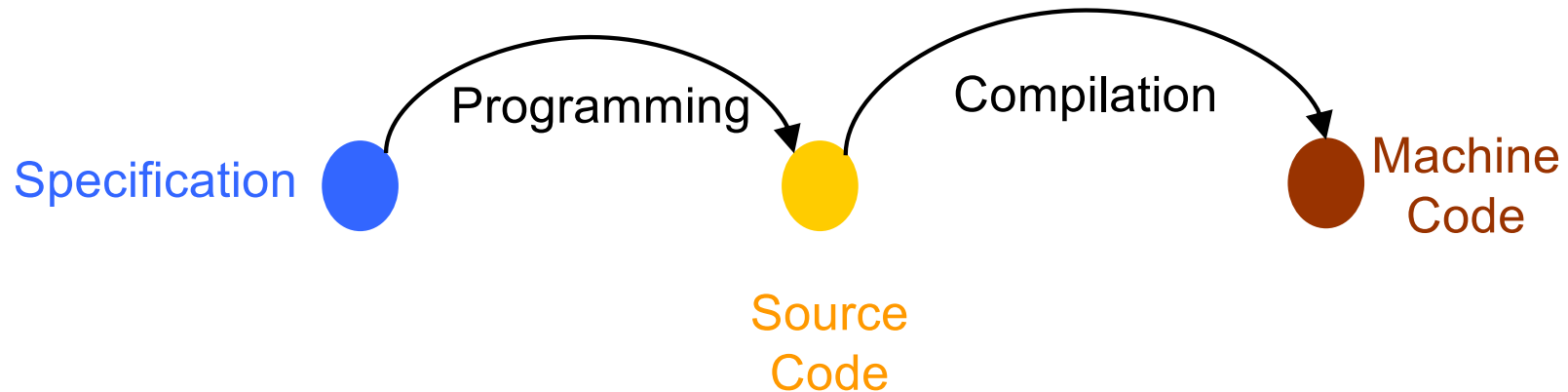
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**E:** [enquiries@ic-resources.com](mailto:enquiries@ic-resources.com)



| Experience                    |                   | Graduate | 3 years | 5 years | 10 years | 12+ years |
|-------------------------------|-------------------|----------|---------|---------|----------|-----------|
| Digital IC Design             | <i>Perm (p.a)</i> | £34,000  | £42,000 | £52,000 | £65,000  | £75,000+  |
|                               | <i>Cont (p.h)</i> | -        | £42     | £48     | £50      | £52+      |
| Digital IC Verification       |                   | £34,000  | £42,000 | £55,000 | £65,000  | £80,000+  |
|                               |                   | -        | £42     | £48     | £52      | £55+      |
| Physical Design               |                   | £34,000  | £42,000 | £52,000 | £65,000  | £75,000+  |
|                               |                   | -        | £40     | £46     | £50      | £52+      |
| FPGA Design                   |                   | £31,000  | £40,000 | £47,000 | £60,000  | £70,000+  |
|                               |                   | -        | £40     | £48     | £50      | £52+      |
| Analog/Mixed Signal IC Design |                   | £34,000  | £42,000 | £52,000 | £65,000  | £75,000+  |
|                               |                   | -        | £42     | £48     | £52      | £55+      |
| RF IC Design                  |                   | £37,000  | £45,000 | £57,000 | £70,000  | £85,000+  |
|                               |                   | -        | £42     | £48     | £52      | £55+      |
| Analog / RF Layout            |                   | £30,000  | £38,000 | £41,000 | £52,000  | £60,000+  |
|                               |                   | -        | £40     | £45     | £50      | £50+      |
| IC Test                       |                   | £32,000  | £38,000 | £40,000 | £45,000  | £60,000+  |
|                               |                   | -        | £45     | £50     | £55      | £60+      |
| IC Process                    |                   | £32,000  | £38,000 | £40,000 | £45,000  | £60,000   |
|                               |                   | -        | -       | -       | -        | -         |

# Reconvergence Models – another example

- In SW development, the transformative process from specification to source code is “programming”.
- The compiler then translates source code to machine code.



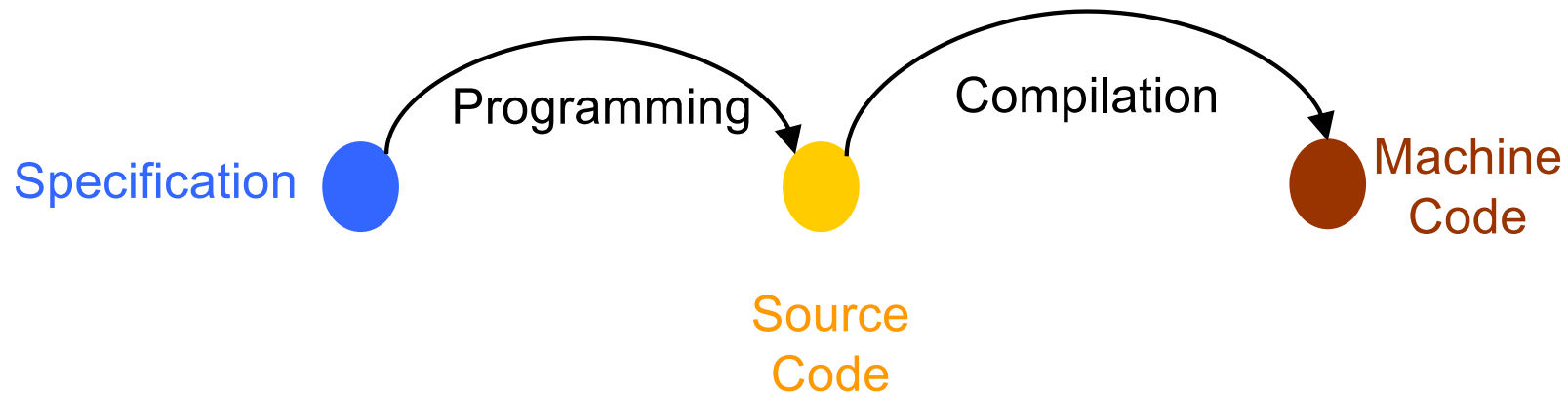
This slide is intentionally  
left blank for you to take  
some time to attempt the  
task on the  
reconvergence model on  
programming 😊

Please do not proceed until you've tried  
– you'll learn more if you try.



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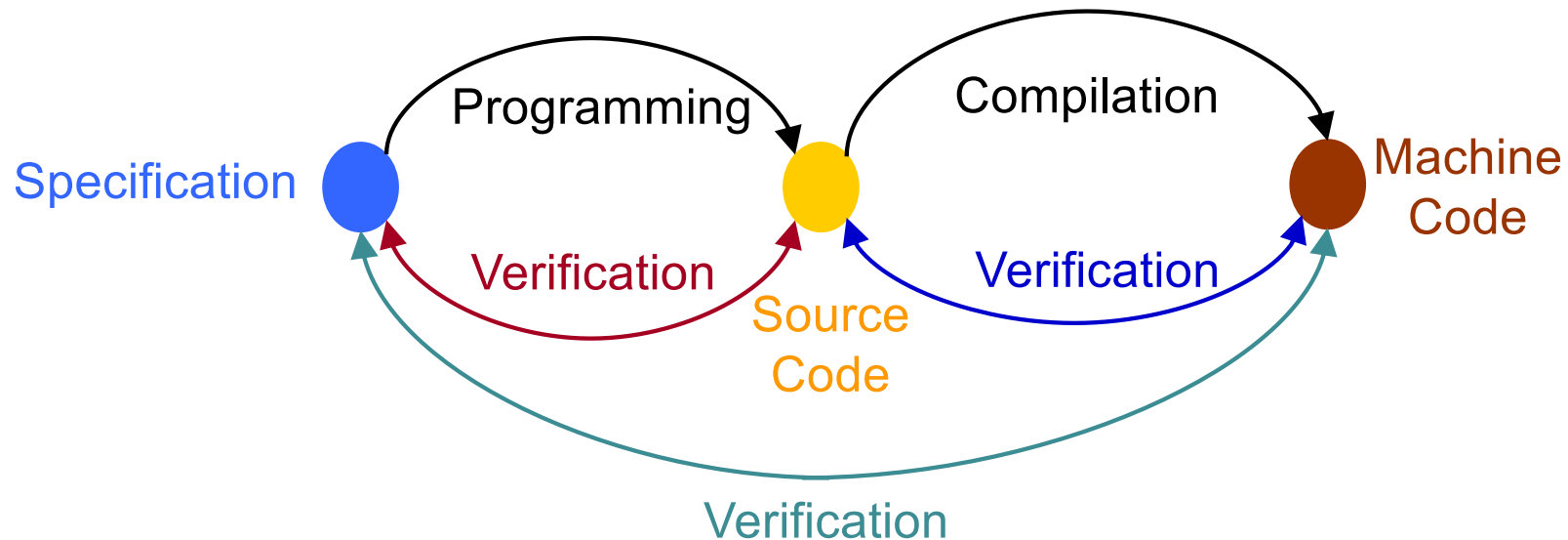


- If your program does not work, why could this be?
  - Bugs in the programming
  - Bugs in the compiler
  - Misunderstanding of the specification
  - .... <What else?>



# Reconvergence Models – another example

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